



UBER's new test track

UBER has bought 600 acres in Pittsburgh to build a new test track for their self-driving cars <https://digit.in/jan20-57>



No steering wheels

GM has sought a permit to build autonomous cars which will not have steering wheels <https://digit.in/jan20-58>

Google Nest Mini

Doesn't beat the Echo Mini

Google might've delayed the launch of the Nest Hub smart display in India but it's not taking a chance with its newest smart speaker, the Nest Mini. The Google Nest Mini, of course, is a successor to the Google Home Mini and a direct competitor to the third-generation Amazon Echo Dot.

Design and Build

Yes, the Google Nest Mini is admittedly very similar to the Home Mini in appearance but there are a few subtle changes. To start with, the Nest Mini gets a wall mount on the back. The other difference is that the fabric that's wrapped around the speaker is custom-made from 100 per cent recycled plastic bottles. On the device, there are LED-lit three haptic buttons (one on top for action, two on the sides for volume control) and a tiny sliding switch on the side that turns the microphone off.

Sadly, there's no 3.5 mm jack included for audio output in the Google Nest Mini. Amazon, on the other hand, has outfitted all its mainstream Echo devices (even the newly launched Amazon Echo Flex) with a 3.5 mm audio jack, thereby giving the user a chance to hook their device up to a more powerful set of external speakers while retaining 'smart' functionality.

Setup

Setting the Google Nest Mini up is quite easy. Plug the speaker in then download and launch the Google Home app on your Android or iOS smartphone/tablet. The app then tells you how to go about connecting the Nest Mini to a Wi-Fi network. The entire setup process lasts about ten or fifteen minutes because there are plenty of questions for you to answer along the way. In the last step, you



FEATURES.....	74
PERFORMANCE.....	63
VALUE.....	60
BUILD	48

can either go with the usual Google Assistant female voice, or choose a new male voice that was introduced with the Nest Mini.

On the review unit, we had a tough time getting a nearby smart appliances to work using Google Assistant. Even though the

Home app reported that Google had made a successful connection with our Mi account, the speaker could not control the Xiaomi Mi Air Purifier 2S. What's more, changing Wi-Fi networks was a bigger pain than we had anticipated. Because the device has to be set up afresh with every network change, it will take you in excess of fifteen minutes to get it up and running if you decide to move it to another location.

Features and User Interface

At the heart of the device, there's a dedicated machine learning chip with one TeraOPS of processing power, which Google claims results in faster response time. We were nonetheless able to use the speaker effectively to get answers about the weather, local businesses, recent news, general knowledge about seven times out of ten. The other three times, Google either failed to catch the voice command or did not know the answer.

During our time with the review unit, we were able to play most songs with English titles without much trouble. For example, saying, "OK Google,

play Snoop Dogg's Drop It Like It's Hot", would work as intended. However, titles of songs in other regional and foreign languages often went misunderstood. For example, saying, "OK Google, play Golpe de Estado by Daddy Yankee" would often result in the speaker playing Despacito, a different song by the same requested artist.

Also, the Nest Mini comes with Google's proprietary Ultrasound sensing feature to turn on the volume control lights automatically when the user's hands approach it.

Google's Nest ecosystem comes with native support for music sources such as Spotify, YouTube Music, TuneIn, Gaana (ad-free playback), and Jio Saavn. Sadly, it misses Apple Music, a source Amazon recently incorporated in its Echo ecosystem. Additionally, you can set up Netflix to be cast on any Chromecast-enabled display.

Audio Quality

Google has improved the sound quality on the new Nest Mini significantly. The device now comes with a new custom speaker driver combined with Google's proprietary tuning software, which results in 2x stronger bass response. This, we found to be true on the test unit without a trace of doubt. The Nest Mini delivered clear, distinct lows, highs, and mids when the music volume was maintained between 50 and 70 per cent.

Bottom Line

The Google Nest Mini is no doubt leagues ahead of its predecessor, the 2017-launched Google Home Mini, in terms of sound quality, response time and overall usability, but it still falls short of features when compared to the Amazon Echo Dot.

—Vignesh Giridharan

SPECIFICATIONS

PROCESSOR: Quad-core 64-bit ARM CPU 1.4 GHz | SENSORS: 3 far-field microphones, capacitive touch | DRIVERS: 40 mm | CONNECTIVITY: 802.11ac dual band, Bluetooth 5.0, Chromecast built-in | WEIGHT: 181 g | DIMENSIONS (LXWXD): 98 mm dia, 42 mm height | WARRANTY: 1 year.

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